Picture-Book Production Playbook — Master System Doc (living)

Born from "Harlow's Accidental Journey" (2026). Updated as the system improves. This is the best-of-the-best of everything learned: methods, practices, styles, prompts, recipes, file discipline, character continuity — the whole machine, reusable for any future book.

---

1. The pipeline (three lanes)

1. **ChatGPT lane — likeness testing.** Paste-ready prompts + attached reference portraits. Fast iteration, honest verdicts. Test likeness here first: attach the Latest Canonical portraits, forbid redesign. Never train on an AI-generated version of a portrait — always re-attach the ORIGINAL.

2. **ComfyUI lane — production.** IPAdapter wired per character (one node per character, strength 0.6–0.8). Positive prompt from the pack; negative prompt always includes: text, words, letters, typography, watermark, logo, signature, speech bubbles, extra limbs, deformed paws, morphed face, off-model character, inconsistent character design, blurry, low quality, photorealistic, 3d render, dark gloomy, scary.

3. **LoRA endgame.** A character LoRA (trained on the local GPU) is the final identity lock for production runs.

> Rule: recommended path is test likeness in ChatGPT first, production on ComfyUI with IPAdapter, LoRA as the endgame.

2. The style anchor system (the single biggest win)

- Every art prompt opens with the STYLE ANCHOR block, verbatim, baked into the copy-paste prompt — the user never adds it by hand.
- The user attaches the current anchor image to every run.

- The anchor is LIVING: it starts as the best available artwork and ratchets forward — whenever a new spread beats the bar, it becomes the anchor.
- The block tells the model: style reference ONLY (painting style, detail density, color richness, light, finish). Scene, characters, and composition come from the prompt, NOT the anchor image.

Verbatim block:

`text

STYLE ANCHOR: An image of the book's current best artwork is attached. It is your STYLE reference ONLY — take its painting style, detail density, color richness, warm cinematic light, and polished finish. The scene, characters, and composition come from this prompt's description below, NOT from the style image. Match the style anchor's quality bar exactly: rich detailed children's picture-book painting, refined visible brushwork, dimensional shading, lush detail. Always storybook — never photorealistic, never 3D render, never flat cartoon.

`

Lesson learned: "soft simplified watercolor" produced pages flatter than the bar. Rich detailed storybook painting anchored to a real image is what holds the quality line.

3. Prompt architecture (anatomy of a working prompt)

Every spread prompt has the same skeleton, in this order:

1. **STYLE ANCHOR block** (verbatim, see §2).

2. **ATTACH checklist** — numbered, exact file names (style anchor image, base/scene reference if a revision, character files). Jon attaches these in ChatGPT; the list tells him exactly what to add.

3. **REFERENCE LINKS** — Drive `uc?export=download` links for every character, baked into the prompt to try first. If any character comes back off-model, the link didn't load: attach that file from the checklist and re-run. (Learned on Sweet Pea: v1's generic pig meant the link failed

silently; the attach fixed it.)

4. **Reference hierarchy** — one line: portraits win on likeness, vehicle/prop refs win on their subject, style anchor wins on finish, latest approved spread wins on staging. Stated explicitly so the model doesn't blend them.

5. **CHARACTERS** — per character: exact visual spec + NEVER-CHANGE list + expression (see §4). "Do not beautify, de-age, or genericize" for real people.

6. **SCENE** — the story beat rendered as a visual moment, checked against the actual locked copy (see §9).

7. **COMPOSITION** — the critical part models skip. Text zone defined as explicit coordinates (x/y percentages). "Compose the sky first, build the scene to the right of it" beats "leave space for text." Faces and key action kept out of the gutter by name.

8. **RENDER** — finish restatement tied to the anchor.

9. **HARD RULES** — textless (enumerated: no words, letters, signage, house numbers, plate text, speech bubbles, watermarks), format (2:1), gutter (center 15% clear), full-bleed.

4. Expression system (no dead faces)

- Kids' book rule: every character gets an emotion word in every prompt. No resting mad-face, no animal staring at nothing.
- Per-page EXPRESSION lines are written fresh from each spread's story beat — never copy-pasted between pages. If every prompt says "warm smile," the model converges on one default face (caught on p1/p2: identical beam + head-lean).
- Build an EXPRESSION MAP for the whole book up front: one distinct emotion per spread for the lead, differentiated smiles for recurring humans (e.g., gardening contentment vs. road-trip beaming vs. market wonder vs. reunion joy), and an emotion word for every supporting animal.
- Comic beats get comic expressions (indignant, sheepish, startled) — grumpy is fine, mean never is.
- **Animals stay animals.** Comic expressions must be rendered in animal body language, not human pantomime (caught on p4, 2026-10-09: Harlow rearing up on hind legs, paws clutched to his chest — a human panic in a cat suit).

Direction: the cat stays on all fours, leaning the whole body back; disgust = wrinkled nose, ears tipped slightly back, eyes narrowed, one dainty lifted paw. A cat's "nope." Subtle, readable, feline — never human gasping or cartoon panic.

5. Layout system (locked before art starts)

- **Format:** 24 full-bleed 2:1 spreads. One layout system for the whole book — no split left/right page designs mid-project (that's a redesign conversation, not a prompt tweak).
- **Text zone:** upper-left, x8–38% width, y5–30% height. Quiet open sky, low detail, no intrusions. Enforce in COMPOSITION, not just hard rules — tell the model what may NOT enter the region.
- **Gutter:** center 15% (x42.5–57.5%) reserved. No faces, no key action, no text zone touching it. Check hair/ears, not just face centers.
- **Interior art is TEXTLESS.** Title and copy are typeset separately at layout. Faces and critical action stay out of the gutter.
- Front matter map (physical pages) must be locked before final print layout — dedications and about-the-author pages shift everything.

6. Review checklist (pre-prompt + post-candidate)

Run these checks on every spread. Pre-prompt checks happen before the prompt is written; post-candidate checks happen on every candidate before it's called good. (Locked 2026-10-09, Jon — these are mechanics, not taste.)

Pre-prompt (before writing):

1. **Read the locked copy** for the spread — scene, emotion, key objects — from the story doc, never from a beat summary alone. The prompt is story-checked against the actual words.

2. **Copy length sets the text zone:** short copy (~40 words or less) = one upper zone; medium (~40–80) = upper band; long (80+, or any copy that reads as "flows across both pages") = full quiet upper band across the whole spread. p4's ~75 words needs both pages.

2b. **Easter-egg cast check:** rev.8 ends with a "Special Appearances — Easter-Egg

Cast" list hiding friends in specific spreads. Check it for every spread BEFORE writing the prompt — these characters are not in the dialogue copy and are easy to miss (caught on p6, 2026-10-09: Dallas the Yorkie belongs on the farm with Molly & Albie). The full list lives in §13.

2c. **Time of day:** the book progresses through a single day — state the light in every prompt so spreads don't jump from noon to dusk and back. Full two-day arc lives in LIGHT-TIMELINE.md (local + Drive). Rough map: Day 1 = p1 morning → p17 night ballpark; overnight gap; Day 2 = p18 dawn beach → p24 night fireplace. Copy cues: p4 "toasty" = midday, p20 "sunny beach" = midday, p8–p9 "hours later" = evening arrival.

3. **Relative sizes:** state species-appropriate sizing explicitly in the prompt (pig visibly bigger than the cat; donkey bigger than the cat; etc.). The model defaults to same-size animals — never leave size to chance.

4. **Build check:** note each animal's build against its canonical portrait (sleek vs. heavyset, young vs. old face). Drift accumulates across rounds — name the build every time.

Post-candidate (before calling it good):

1. **Story match:** does the image show what the copy says? Scene, action, mood.

2. **Likeness:** each character vs. their canonical portrait — face, markings, build. No older, fluffier, or fatter than the reference.

3. **Relative sizes:** species-appropriate, as specified.

4. **Text zone:** clean and sized to the copy load. Faint clouds fine; structures, treetops, and busy detail are not.

5. **Gutter:** no faces, hair, ears, or key action in the center 15% (x42.5–57.5%).

6. **Animals stay animals:** expressions in animal body language, never human pantomime.

7. **Style bar:** matches the anchor's finish — never photorealistic, never 3D, never flat.

8. **Textless:** no words, letters, signage, or watermarks anywhere.

7. Character continuity system

- **Latest Canonical folder** holds the one true portrait per character. Replaced portraits go to a Previous Versions archive — never trash.
- **Character recipes:** full NEVER-CHANGE spec + reusable render prompt per character. Bank the best ones as standalone docs (the p2 Mustang spread recipe is the template for thoroughness).
- **Real people:** exact portrait identity, mature features kept, no de-aging/beautifying/genericizing. Clothing and accessories are part of identity (e.g., the brooch is a bow, not a flower).
- **White-face canon example:** when the book design overrides reality (Harlow's white muzzle vs. the real cat's dark mask), write the canon down and revise any doc that contradicts it, or the old rule will fight the new art.
- Verify uploaded image bytes before banking (an iOS upload once landed with crossed bytes — check dimensions + pixel signature, never trust the path alone).
- **Attachments beat links.** If a character comes back generic-looking, the Drive reference URL didn't load — the model improvised instead (caught on p4, 2026-10-09: Sweet Pea rendered as a generic cartoon pig with eyelashes, not her portrait). Re-run with the file attached directly. Links are convenience, attachments are guarantee.

8. File discipline (Jon's lock)

- **Working folders hold only the latest and greatest.** Final Spreads = one current best per spread, no duplicates.
- **Everything else goes to Spread Alternates, clearly labeled** (page number + what it is + why it lost: "text zone too busy," "replaced by v6"). Never trash — old versions carry reusable elements (poses, backgrounds, faces).
- **Choose winners only when all candidates are present.** No premature locks.
- Naming: `Page NN - Name.ext` (NN = story spread number). Redos: `Spread pN redo vN - note.jpg`.

9. Copy workflow

- Compare the author's originals against any AI-assisted rewrite, then do a best-of-the-best pass combining them.
- Lock the copy before art production. Late copy changes are handled if they come — they don't block art.
- Every art prompt is story-checked against the LOCKED copy, not just a beat summary. If copy changes later, recheck affected spreads.

10. Iteration method

- Save every candidate (see §8).
- Prefer **targeted revision passes**: attach the latest image as the scene reference, list ONLY what changes ("change these two things, everything else identical"). Full re-rolls risk losing what worked.
- Give honest verdicts: name what's working, name what fails, say whether it's worth another pass or a keeper.
- One crisp vote with one reason when asked to choose. Don't relitigate after the call.
- **Recipe ritual (standing):** the moment a spread is agreed done, Trinity hands Jon the recipe-request prompt with the correct page number filled in. Jon pastes it to ChatGPT, sends the recipe back, Trinity banks it (local + Drive Character Recipes). No winner is fully closed until its recipe is banked.

11. Print (verify before layout)

Provisional values only until the actual product/template is chosen: 0.125" bleed, 0.5" content safety margin, 0.2" minimum inner gutter margin, 300 PPI minimum. Lock trim, spine, cover template, color profile, and safe areas from the real template before layout — never from memory.

12. Standing locks from HBA

- Title: **Harlow's Accidental Journey**. "HBA / Harlow's Big Adventure" =

internal shorthand only. "Unexpected Journey" = rejected (too close to Tolkien).

- Don't contact the author (Lois) without showing Jon the exact message and getting explicit approval.
- Nothing goes to print until the spread winner review, cover runoff, and title-treatment runoff are all complete.

13. Easter-egg cast — hidden friends (from Mom's original draft, rev.8)

Tucked into scenes throughout the book. They do not appear in the dialogue copy — check this list for every spread or they get missed:

- p3: Nero the cat — marketplace with Lois ✓ (in the p3 winner)
- p6: Dallas the Yorkie — with Molly & Albie on the farm
- p7: Dynamite the pony — with Chester the laughing horse
- p8: Paco the greyhound — with the red pick-up truck
- p10: French Fry the dog — with Philly the rat in the city
- p11: Endeavor the calico cat — with Penelope in the city
- p12: Chowder & Monkey the Chihuahuas — with Otis the coyote
- p13: Tiger the cat — with Gideon the pigeon
- p14: Nicholas & Norman the guinea pigs — with Chippy at the baseball park
- p21: Cash the cockatiel — with Helga on the beach
- p22: Mittens the cat + Teddy the cat — ghostly guardian angels on the road home

Rule: Easter eggs stay small and secondary — tucked near the main action, never competing with the story beat, never breaking the text zone or gutter.

Update this doc whenever the system levels up. Newest dated entry wins.